help them all these years. Their only support had come from human rights activists, such as Teesta Setalvad, who were branded as anti-national by Modi's men. 'Couldn't such a big man like Modi come even once and speak to us?' Rupa Mody asked me tearfully. As a father of a lanky teenage son myself, I couldn't hold back my tears.

For the same news documentary I also travelled to a slum colony, Citizen Nagar, on the outskirts of Ahmedabad. Here, the riot-affected families had been literally 'dumped' in subhuman conditions near a large garbage mound into which the city's waste flowed. 'Modi talks of Vibrant Gujarat, but for whom is this Vibrant Gujarat, only for the rich?' one of the locals asked me angrily. In Juhapura, a Muslim ghetto in the heart of Ahmedabad—sometimes referred to as the city's Gaza Strip—the mood was equally unforgiving. 'Modi goes everywhere marketing himself, why doesn't he come to Juhapura?' was a question posed by many out there.

Interestingly, the more affluent Muslims had made their peace with Modi. Many Gujarati Bohra Muslims are traders and businessmen—they were ready to break bread with Modi so long as he could assure them a return to communal harmony and rapid economic growth. In my grandmother's building in the walled city, there were many Muslim middle-class families who had reconciled themselves to a Modi-led Gujarat. 'We have no problem with Modiji so long as we get security,' one of them told me. Many younger, educated Muslims too seemed ready to give him a chance. 'It's ten years now since the riots, it's time to move on,' was how a young management graduate explained his position.

And yet, how do you move on when your house has been razed and your relatives killed? Modi has claimed that his government's track record in prosecuting the guilty was much better than the Congress's in 1984. One of his ministers, Maya Kodnani, was among those who had received a life sentence. And that Gujarat had seen no major communal outbreak since 2002.

The truth is a little more bitter and complex. Yes, 1984 was a terrible shame, but then so was 2002. Any comparisons in death toll figures would reduce human lives to a tragic zero-sum game—'my riot' versus 'your riot'.